Unit – 4

Nobel Prize



Since 1901, the Nobel Prize has been honoring men and women from all corners of the globe for outstanding achievements in physics, chemistry, medicine, literature, and for work in peace. The foundations for the prize were laid in 1895 when Alfred Nobel wrote his last will, leaving much of his wealth to the establishment of the Nobel Prize.

The Nobel Committee, in fact, a notoriously conservative body which among other things had a marked antipathy to pure sciences, especially to Mathematical Physics. Restrained .by a clause in Alfred Nobel's will that the prize should go to the person whose 'discovery or invention' shall have conferred the greatest benefit to mankind, the committee initially ignored the great theoretical advances in Physics. Wracked, no doubt, by guilt that he had become a merchant of death through his invention of dynamite and smokeless powder and plagued by sadistic fantasies of destruction, the Swedish chemist, engineer and aspiring poet, Alfred Nobel, who has been described as Europe's richest vagabond, left his colossal fortune to the cause of progress in human knowledge. Five prizes were installed, one each for literature ('to the person who shall have produced in the field of literature, the most outstanding Work of an idealistic tendency), Physics, Chemistry, medicine and peace to the person who shall have done the most or the best work for fraternity among nations for abolition or reduction of armies, and for holding or promotion of peace'.

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